

CAREER GROWTH GUIDE

The Client-Ready English Roadmap

From weak English to confident client calls, emails and interviews —
a 6-month, 45-minutes-a-day plan built for a Pakistani software engineer

Prepared for: Muhammad Nouman

Python Backend Engineer | Founder, Xvera Labs

Speaking

Listening

Client Calls

Emails

Proposals

Interviews

Grammar • Vocabulary • Pronunciation • Speaking Drills • Business English • Technical English

A companion to your Master Career Roadmap — the communication half of the same goal.

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WHY THIS ROADMAP IS DIFFERENT

Most English courses are built for students who need to pass an exam. You don't. You need something much narrower and much more achievable: **the ability to talk to an international client about software, confidently, without freezing**. That is a far smaller target than “learn English” — and you are already closer to it than you think.

Three things that are true, and that change the plan

- ◆ **You already read English every day.** Django docs, Stack Overflow, error messages, this roadmap — your reading and technical vocabulary are far ahead of your speaking. The gap is not knowledge; it's the mouth and the confidence. That is a practice problem, not a study problem.
- ◆ **Clients do not need perfect English.** They need to understand you and trust you. A slight accent and simple sentences are completely fine — hesitation, silence, and unclear updates are what lose contracts. Aim for **clear**, not **perfect**.
- ◆ **Speaking only improves by speaking.** You cannot read your way to fluency, the same way you cannot become a backend engineer by only watching tutorials. This roadmap is therefore ~70% output (speaking and writing) and only ~30% input (grammar, vocabulary, listening).

Target Outcome

Item	Detail
What you'll be able to do	Run a 30-minute client discovery call in English, give weekly project updates, explain a technical decision, handle a scope or delay conversation, and write clear emails and proposals — all without preparing a script first.
What you do NOT need	Perfect grammar, a British/American accent, advanced vocabulary, or IELTS. None of these affect whether a client hires you.
Realistic timeline	45 minutes a day, 6 days a week: noticeably more fluent by month 2, comfortable in a structured client call by month 4, confident and unscripted by month 6.
How it pairs with your career roadmap	Run this in parallel, not before. Your English practice material is your own work — you explain BTR Mall, your Docker setup, your test suite. Two goals, one hour, same material.

The rules

- ◆ **Speak every single day, even for 60 seconds.** Consistency beats intensity. Ten minutes daily beats three hours on Sunday.
- ◆ **Mistakes are the method, not the failure.** If you are not making mistakes, you are staying in your comfort zone and not improving.
- ◆ **Never translate from Urdu in your head.** Learn whole English phrases as single units, so they come out without assembly.
- ◆ **Use your own work as the content.** Don't practice describing a beach; practice describing your database schema. That's what clients ask about.
- ◆ **Record yourself.** It is uncomfortable for the first week and then becomes the single most useful tool you have.

“The goal is not to sound like a native speaker. The goal is that a client in New York or Dubai finishes a call with you thinking ‘this engineer understood my problem and explained the solution clearly.’ That is achievable in six months.”

FIND YOUR STARTING LEVEL

Before you start, spend 15 minutes finding out where you actually are. “My English is weak” is usually not true across all four skills — most Pakistani developers are intermediate at reading and near-beginner at speaking. Knowing which is which stops you wasting months on the wrong thing.

THE 15-MINUTE SELF-TEST

- 1 Reading (3 min):** Open the FastAPI documentation “First Steps” page. Read one section. Can you understand it without Google Translate? Score: Easy / Mostly / Hard.
- 2 Listening (4 min):** Play any 4-minute English tech YouTube video at normal speed with subtitles OFF. How much did you catch? Score: Most of it / Half / Very little.
- 3 Speaking (5 min):** Open your phone's voice recorder. Talk for 2 minutes about what BTR Mall does — no script, no pausing to think of words. Then listen back. Score: Flowed okay / Lots of pauses / Got stuck and stopped.
- 4 Writing (3 min):** Write a 5-sentence email to a client explaining that a feature will be delayed by three days. Time yourself. Score: Under 5 min / 5–10 min / Struggled.

WHAT YOUR SCORES MEAN

Level	What it looks like	Where to start
A2 — Basic	You understand written English but speaking is mostly single words and long pauses. Listening at natural speed is hard.	Start at Phase 1 and give it the full 8 weeks. Do not skip the grammar core.
B1 — Intermediate	You read technical docs comfortably, can write a basic email, but speaking is slow and you translate in your head.	This is where most Pakistani developers actually are. Do Phase 1 in 4 weeks (refresh only), then go hard on Phase 2.
B2 — Upper intermediate	You can hold a conversation but lose fluency under pressure, and professional/negotiation situations feel risky.	Skip most of Phase 1. Go straight to Phase 2 speaking drills and Phase 3 client English.

Do one more thing: save that 2-minute recording in a folder called “Month 0”. In month 3 and month 6, record the same topic again. Hearing the difference is the strongest motivation you will get — progress in language learning is invisible day to day and obvious across months.

THE FOUR SKILLS, RANKED BY WHAT YOU ACTUALLY NEED

All four skills matter, but not equally for your goal. Spend your time in proportion to the impact on client work — not equally across the four, which is how school teaches it and why school English doesn't make you fluent.

Skill	Priority	Why	Time share
Speaking	Highest	This is the actual bottleneck. Client calls, interviews, standups, demo videos — every high-value moment is spoken.	40%
Listening	High	You cannot reply to what you didn't catch. Clients speak fast, with accents, on bad connections. This is half of every conversation.	30%
Writing	Medium	Emails, proposals, Slack, READMEs. Important, but you have time to think and edit — so it's lower risk than speaking.	20%
Reading	Lowest	You already do this daily as a developer. It will improve automatically without dedicated study time.	10%

"If you only have 20 minutes on a busy day, spend all 20 on speaking and listening. Reading and writing will survive the skipped day; speaking is the one that decays."

Vocabulary: quality over quantity

You do not need 10,000 words. For client software work you need roughly **800–1,200 high-frequency words** plus the technical vocabulary you already have. Learn them as phrases, not as isolated words — "happy to walk you through it" is one unit, not four words to assemble under pressure.

- ◆ Keep a single running document (or Anki deck) of phrases you actually needed and didn't have.
- ◆ Add a phrase only when you personally hit the gap — not from a random "500 business phrases" list.
- ◆ Review it out loud for 5 minutes a day. Silent review builds recognition; loud review builds production.

YOUR DAILY 45-MINUTE ROUTINE

This is the engine of the whole roadmap. The content inside each block changes as you move through the phases, but the shape of the day stays the same for six months. Fit it around your existing work at TheTechFury and Xvera Labs — morning before work is usually the most protected slot.

Block	Time	What you do
1. Listening warm-up	10 min	A podcast, tech talk, or YouTube video at normal speed. Subtitles off the first time, on the second time to check what you missed. Passive listening while doing chores does NOT count.
2. Shadowing	10 min	Replay 1–2 minutes of that audio and speak along with it, copying rhythm and stress, not just words. This is the single highest-impact drill for accent and fluency.
3. Speaking output	15 min	The main event. Record a voice note, do a language-exchange call, or narrate a task out loud. Never skip this block — it is where the actual learning happens.
4. Vocabulary & phrases	5 min	Review your phrase document out loud. Add anything you needed today and couldn't say.
5. Writing	5 min	One short piece: an email, a Slack-style update, a commit message written properly, or a paragraph of a README.

WEEKLY ADDITIONS (ON TOP OF THE DAILY 45 MINUTES)

- ◆ **One 30-minute conversation with a real human, every week.** Language exchange partner, an online tutor (italki/Preply are roughly \$5–10/hour for a conversation tutor), or a friend who will hold the line and not switch to Urdu. This is non-negotiable and it is worth paying for.
- ◆ **One recorded 3-minute monologue, every Sunday.** Same format every week: explain something you built. Keep every recording. This is your progress log.
- ◆ **One longer written piece, every week.** A project README, an Upwork proposal, or a LinkedIn post about what you shipped — which also feeds your career roadmap's portfolio goals.

What to do on a day you have 10 minutes and no energy

Record one 60-second voice note about what you worked on today. That's it. A 10-minute day keeps the habit alive; a skipped day starts the chain of skipped days. Protect the streak, not the duration.

THE THREE LEARNING PHASES

Three phases, roughly 32 weeks total. Each one has a different job: Phase 1 fixes the foundation so you stop second-guessing basic sentences, Phase 2 breaks the silence barrier, and Phase 3 turns general fluency into professional, client-facing English. Don't jump ahead — but don't linger either. If you hit the milestone early, move on.

1 Rebuild the Foundation

WEEKS 1–8

Fix the small number of grammar and sound patterns that cause most of your errors — then stop studying grammar forever.

WHAT YOU FOCUS ON

Area	What to actually do
Core tenses (only 5)	Present simple, present continuous, past simple, present perfect, and 'going to / will' for the future. These five cover ~90% of real conversation. Ignore the other seven for now.
Articles: a / an / the	Urdu has no articles, so this is the #1 error for Pakistani speakers. Learn the basic rule, then stop worrying — clients understand you either way.
Prepositions	in / on / at for time and place; common verb pairs (depend ON, listen TO, good AT, responsible FOR). Learn these inside phrases, never as a grammar table.
Question formation	Do you... / Are you... / Have you... / Could you... / What would you... Clients ask questions constantly and you need to ask them back. Drill this until it's automatic.
The 800-word core	The most common 800 English words. You likely know 600 already — find the gaps with any 'most common English words' frequency list.
Sound foundations	Start Section 20 (Pronunciation) now, in parallel. Fixing sounds early is much easier than un-learning them at month 5.

DAILY DRILLS FOR THIS PHASE

- ◆ 10 min listening: slow, clear content (BBC Learning English, English with Lucy, or any tech channel with a clear speaker).
- ◆ 10 min shadowing: one short clip, repeated until your rhythm matches theirs.
- ◆ 15 min speaking: describe your day, your code, or a photo out loud — recorded, alone, no audience. Full sentences only.
- ◆ 5 min phrases + 5 min writing: 3–5 sentences a day, focusing on correct tense and articles.
- ◆ Weekly: one 30-minute conversation with a tutor or exchange partner, from week 3 onward. Do not wait until you feel ready.

YOU'RE READY FOR THE NEXT PHASE WHEN...

"You can speak for 2 minutes about a familiar topic without long silences, and you catch yourself making a tense or article mistake and self-correct mid-sentence. That self-correction is the real signal."

2 Start Speaking, Badly, Every Day

WEEKS 9–20

The longest and most important phase — this is where hesitation turns into flow. Volume of speaking is the only variable that matters here.

WHAT YOU FOCUS ON

Area	What to actually do
Fluency over accuracy	Deliberately stop correcting yourself mid-sentence. Finish the thought, then fix it after. Accuracy comes back on its own once fluency exists; the reverse is not true.
Thinking in English	Narrate small things internally in English — what you're debugging, what you're cooking. The aim is to remove the Urdu→English translation step that causes your pauses.
Filler and buying-time phrases	'That's a good question' / 'Let me think about that for a second' / 'How do I put this...' Native speakers pause too — they just pause in English instead of going silent.
Listening at real speed	Move from graded/slow content to real content: tech podcasts, conference talks, YouTube at 1.0x with subtitles off. Expect to catch 60% at first. That's normal.
Accent exposure	Your clients will be American, British, Australian, Indian, Middle Eastern. Deliberately listen to all of them so no accent catches you off guard on a real call.
Storytelling structure	Practice the shape clients expect: situation → problem → what you did → result. This is also exactly the interview format from your career roadmap.

DAILY DRILLS FOR THIS PHASE

- ◆ Increase speaking to 20–25 minutes/day if you can — this is the phase where extra minutes pay off most.
- ◆ Two 30-minute human conversations per week instead of one. Budget roughly \$40–80/month for a tutor; treat it as a business expense, because it is.
- ◆ Shadow content at natural speed, not slowed down. Struggling is the point.
- ◆ Start Missions 1–3 (Sections 08–10) in this phase — they're designed for exactly this stage.
- ◆ Once a week, speak for 3 minutes on a topic you did NOT prepare. Random-topic practice is what builds real-call confidence.

YOU'RE READY FOR THE NEXT PHASE WHEN...

"You can hold a 30-minute unscripted conversation without your partner switching to Urdu, and you no longer mentally translate before speaking on familiar topics."

3 Professional & Client English

WEEKS 21–32

Narrow everything down to the specific situations that earn you money — calls, updates, negotiations and interviews.

WHAT YOU FOCUS ON

Area	What to actually do
The discovery call	Asking clients the right questions about requirements, budget, timeline and success criteria — and understanding their answers the first time. See the phrasebook in Section 16.
Explaining technical things simply	A non-technical client doesn't want to hear about Redis channel layers. Practice one-sentence business explanations of your technical decisions. Section 17 covers this.
Difficult conversations	Delays, scope creep, price increases, saying no, disagreeing with a client's idea politely. These feel hardest and are worth the most money. Drill them the most.
Professional writing	Proposals, status updates, invoicing follow-ups, contract clarifications. Section 18 gives you the templates.
Interview English	Talking about your experience, your projects, and your trade-offs — the spoken half of your career roadmap's interview prep.
Small talk	The first two minutes of every call. Weather, weekend, where you're based, time zones. Scripted-sounding small talk is fine; silence is not.

DAILY DRILLS FOR THIS PHASE

- ◆ Replace generic speaking practice with role-play: you're the developer, your tutor is a difficult client.
- ◆ Record a mock client call every week and listen back specifically for: unclear sentences, long silences, and moments you gave up on a word.
- ◆ Run Missions 4–8 (Sections 11–15) through this phase — they move you from practice into real, paid situations.
- ◆ Read your Upwork proposals out loud before sending. If you can't say it comfortably, it's too complicated to write.
- ◆ Watch recorded sales/discovery calls on YouTube and note the exact phrases used to redirect, clarify, and close.

YOU'RE READY FOR THE NEXT PHASE WHEN...

"You have completed a real client call in English end-to-end, without a script, and the client understood you and moved forward. At that point this roadmap has done its job — everything after is maintenance and refinement."

EIGHT PRACTICE MISSIONS

Reading about English does nothing. These eight missions are the equivalent of the projects in your career roadmap — concrete things you build and ship, each one harder than the last, ending with a real paid client call. Start Mission 1 in week 1; start Mission 8 when you're genuinely ready, around month 5–6.

1 The 60-Second Daily Voice Note

FOUNDATIONAL

One minute of recorded speech, every single day, starting today.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

This is the smallest possible speaking habit, which is exactly why it works. It removes the two biggest blockers at once: not having anyone to talk to, and being embarrassed to speak. A phone recorder never judges you, and 60 seconds is short enough that you can never justify skipping it.

WHAT YOU NEED

Phone voice recorder	A folder to store recordings	Nothing else
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ The habit of producing English out loud daily, which is the entire foundation of this roadmap
- ◆ Tolerance for hearing your own voice — uncomfortable for a week, then fine forever
- ◆ An objective record of your progress that you cannot argue with

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Every evening, open your voice recorder and speak for 60 seconds about what you did that day at work.
- 2 Do not write a script. Do not restart when you make a mistake — push through to the end.
- 3 Listen back once. Note one thing you couldn't say and add the correct phrase to your phrase document.
- 4 Save it with the date. Never delete a recording.
- 5 Every 4 weeks, listen to your recording from 4 weeks ago and compare.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Writing a script first — this turns a speaking exercise into a reading exercise and kills the benefit.
- ◆ Deleting recordings you dislike — those are the ones that prove progress later.
- ◆ Stopping and restarting every time you stumble. Recovering mid-sentence is the exact skill you need on calls.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

"Attach it to something you already do daily — right after you close your laptop, or right before you sleep. Habits attached to existing habits survive; habits that need willpower don't."

Suggested time: 60 seconds/day, forever

2 Shadowing a Native Speaker

FOUNDATIONAL

Speak along with real English audio, copying rhythm and stress, not just words.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

Shadowing is the highest-return drill in language learning and almost nobody does it. It trains your mouth muscles, your rhythm, and your listening at the same time. Two weeks of consistent shadowing changes how you sound more than two months of grammar study.

WHAT YOU NEED

YouTube or a podcast app	Headphones	10 minutes
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ Natural rhythm and word stress — the thing that makes speech sound fluent rather than word-by-word
- ◆ Faster listening comprehension, because your mouth learns the patterns your ear is trying to catch
- ◆ Pronunciation improvement without studying pronunciation rules

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Pick a 1–2 minute clip of a clear English speaker. Tech talks and interviews work well and teach relevant vocabulary.
- 2 Listen once, just to understand.
- 3 Play it again and speak along at the same time, slightly behind the speaker — copying their speed, pauses, and emphasis.
- 4 Repeat the same clip 5–10 times over the session. Repetition of one clip beats variety here.
- 5 Record yourself shadowing on the last attempt and compare it to the original.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Choosing clips that are too long — 60–120 seconds is the right size; anything longer and you'll stop doing it.
- ◆ Reading a transcript while shadowing — this makes it a reading drill. Use your ears only.
- ◆ Switching to a new clip every day. Stay on one clip for 3–4 days until it feels easy.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

“Choose clips from your own field. Shadowing a senior engineer explaining system design teaches you rhythm AND the exact vocabulary you'll need in a technical interview.”

Suggested time: 10 min/day, weeks 1–20

3 Narrate Your Own Code Out Loud

INTERMEDIATE

Explain what you're building, in English, while you build it.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

This solves the biggest practical problem: finding time and material. You're already writing code for 8 hours a day — narrating it costs you almost no extra time and builds exactly the vocabulary a client or interviewer will ask about. It also exposes, immediately, which technical concepts you can't explain in English yet.

WHAT YOU NEED

Your existing work (BTR Mall, client projects)	Voice recorder	Your phrase document
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ Technical explanation vocabulary you will use in every interview and client call
- ◆ The ability to explain a decision, not just describe code — 'I used X because Y'
- ◆ Discovery of your specific vocabulary gaps, in the exact domain you need them

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Before starting a task, say out loud in English what you're about to do and why.
- 2 While debugging, narrate your reasoning: 'The request is returning 500, so I'm going to check the serializer first.'
- 3 After finishing, record a 2-minute explanation of what you built and what trade-off you made.
- 4 Every time you reach for an Urdu word, stop and write down the English phrase you needed.
- 5 Once a week, explain one feature as if to a non-technical client — no jargon allowed.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Only describing what the code does, never why you chose it — clients and interviewers care about the why.
- ◆ Using heavy jargon to hide weak English; it makes you harder to understand, not more impressive.
- ◆ Doing it silently in your head. It must be out loud to count.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

"The non-technical version is the hard one and the valuable one. If you can explain your Celery task queue to your mother in simple English, you can explain it to a client."

Suggested time: 15 min/day, weeks 9 onward

4 The Weekly Written Update

INTERMEDIATE

Write the project status update a real client would receive — every Friday, whether or not anyone reads it.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

Clients judge your professionalism heavily on written updates, and this is the one area where you have time to think. A clear weekly update is also the single easiest way to look reliable to an international client, which is what gets contracts renewed.

WHAT YOU NEED

Email or a doc	Your week's actual work	Grammarly (free tier)
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ A repeatable structure you can write in 10 minutes instead of agonizing over
- ◆ Professional written tone — direct, clear, not over-formal
- ◆ The habit of flagging problems early in writing, which is a senior-engineer behaviour in any language

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Every Friday, write an update with four parts: what shipped this week, what's in progress, what's blocked, what's next week.
- 2 Keep it under 200 words. Short updates get read; long ones don't.
- 3 Run it through Grammarly, but read every suggested change and understand why — don't just click accept.
- 4 Rewrite one sentence to be simpler than Grammarly suggested. Simple beats impressive.
- 5 Send it to a real recipient where possible: a current client, your TheTechFury lead, or even yourself.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Hiding bad news or delays until the last moment — clients forgive delays, not surprises.
- ◆ Over-formal language ('Please do the needful', 'Kindly revert back') — see Section 19; this sounds dated to Western clients.
- ◆ Writing long paragraphs. Use short lines and bullet points.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

"Keep every update in one folder. After three months you'll have a template library and writing them will take five minutes instead of thirty."

Suggested time: 20 min/week, from week 5

5 Mock Client Discovery Call

ADVANCED

A full 30-minute fake client call with a tutor or partner, run as if the contract is real.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

This is where all the pieces get tested under pressure. Discovery calls are the highest-stakes English you'll do — they decide whether you get the project. Doing ten fake ones means the first real one isn't the first one.

WHAT YOU NEED

italki/Preply tutor	Zoom or Google Meet	Recording enabled	A prepared scenario
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ Asking clarifying questions in real time instead of nodding and hoping
- ◆ Handling the moment you don't understand — asking someone to repeat without losing credibility
- ◆ Quoting timelines and pricing out loud, which is surprisingly hard the first time

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Give your tutor a scenario: 'You run a small online store and want a mobile app. You're not technical and your budget is unclear.'
- 2 Run the full call: greeting and small talk, understanding their problem, asking about budget and timeline, explaining your approach, agreeing next steps.
- 3 Record it. Ask the tutor for three specific corrections at the end, not general feedback.
- 4 Listen back and note every point where you went silent or gave up on a sentence.
- 5 Run the same scenario again a week later and compare.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Preparing a script — real clients go off-script in the first two minutes.
- ◆ Pretending to understand when you didn't. Learn the polite repair phrases in Section 16 and use them.
- ◆ Only practicing easy clients. Ask your tutor to sometimes be vague, impatient, or to push back on your price.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

"Ask your tutor to deliberately speak fast and unclearly on one call. Clients on bad connections are the real test, and being comfortable saying 'Sorry, you cut out — could you say that again?' is worth a lot."

Suggested time: 30 min/week, weeks 21–32

6 Write & Send 10 Real Proposals

ADVANCED

Ten actual Upwork/email proposals to real postings — sent, not drafted.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

Proposals are where written English directly converts into money. They also force a specific skill: explaining in three short paragraphs why you're the right person, in a client's language rather than a developer's. Ten real ones teach you more than any template.

WHAT YOU NEED

Upwork/Contra account	Your portfolio links	Your project case studies
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ Writing persuasively and briefly — clients read the first two lines and decide
- ◆ Translating technical work into client benefits ('faster checkout' not 'Redis caching layer')
- ◆ Handling rejection and non-response in a second language without losing momentum

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Find 10 real postings that match your Django/DRF/full-stack skills.
- 2 For each, write a proposal with: one line showing you read their post, one short paragraph on a similar thing you built, one clear next step.
- 3 Never use the same proposal twice — clients can tell instantly.
- 4 Read each one out loud before sending. If it's hard to say, it's too complicated.
- 5 Track which ones got replies and what was different about them.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Opening with 'Dear Sir/Madam, I am a hardworking developer' — this reads as a template and gets skipped.
- ◆ Listing every technology you know instead of the two that matter for their project.
- ◆ Writing 600 words. Under 150 gets read; over 300 does not.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

"Keep a file of the proposals that got replies. Your own successful proposals are a better template than anything you'll find online, because they're in your voice and your niche."

Suggested time: Weeks 25–32, alongside your career roadmap job search

7 Record a Project Demo Video

ADVANCED

A 90-second English walkthrough of one of your real projects — published, not private.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

Your career roadmap already asks for a demo video on your portfolio. This mission is where the two roadmaps meet: a clear spoken demo simultaneously proves your engineering and your English to every visitor, before you ever get on a call with them.

WHAT YOU NEED

Loom or OBS	A working project (BTR Mall, Goal Line Report)	Headset mic
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ Concise spoken explanation under recording pressure
- ◆ Structuring a demo: what problem it solves → show it working → one interesting technical decision
- ◆ A reusable portfolio asset that works for you while you sleep

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Pick one project and write down only a 5-point outline — not a full script.
- 2 Record a first take. It will be bad. Keep going.
- 3 Re-record until you get one clean 90-second take. Expect 5–15 attempts the first time, 2–3 by the third video.
- 4 Do not edit out every pause — a natural pause sounds human; a hyper-edited video sounds nervous.
- 5 Publish it on your portfolio page and LinkedIn.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Reading a script word for word — it's immediately obvious and less persuasive than imperfect natural speech.
- ◆ Spending 20 minutes explaining architecture. Ninety seconds, one idea, one demo.
- ◆ Never publishing it because it isn't perfect. A published imperfect video beats a perfect unpublished one.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

“Do one video per project across months 4–6. By the last one you'll notice you need three takes instead of fifteen — that's measurable fluency progress, in public.”

Suggested time: Weeks 21–32, one per project

8 First Real Paid Client Call in English

CAPSTONE

The real thing: an actual international client, an actual call, actual money on the line.

WHY THIS MISSION MATTERS

This is the mission the whole roadmap exists for. Everything before it is preparation. Do it once and the psychological barrier breaks permanently — almost every developer reports that the second call feels dramatically easier than the first.

WHAT YOU NEED

Everything from Missions 1–7	A real prospect or client	A quiet room and stable internet
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WHAT IT BUILDS

- ◆ Proof, to yourself, that your English is sufficient for the work you want
- ◆ Real feedback that no amount of practice can give you
- ◆ The start of USD-denominated client relationships, which is the point of both roadmaps

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Take a small, low-risk project first — a \$200–500 contract is perfect for a first English call.
- 2 Prepare your opening 30 seconds and your three key questions. Do not prepare beyond that.
- 3 Test your audio setup 10 minutes before. Bad audio makes good English sound bad.
- 4 Ask for the call to be recorded ('Do you mind if I record this so I don't miss any requirements?') — it's professional and gives you review material.
- 5 After the call, listen back and write down the three moments you struggled most. Those become next week's practice topics.

COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ◆ Waiting until you feel 'ready' — you won't. Month 5 with imperfect English beats month 18 with perfect English and no clients.
- ◆ Apologizing for your English at the start. It plants doubt that wasn't there. Just speak.
- ◆ Taking a huge first contract where a misunderstanding is expensive. Start small deliberately.

HOW TO MAKE IT STICK

"Schedule the call before you feel ready. A booked call in your calendar produces more improvement in one week than a month of optional practice."

Suggested time: Target: month 5–6

THE CLIENT COMMUNICATION PHRASEBOOK

These are the exact phrases for the situations that actually come up. Learn them as whole units and say them out loud until they're automatic — under pressure you will not have time to build a sentence from grammar rules. This section is the one to keep open on a second monitor during real calls.

Starting the call

Situation	What to say
Opening	"Hi [name], thanks for making the time today. Can you hear me okay?"
Small talk	"How's your week going?" / "What time is it there? I'm in Pakistan, so we're about [X] hours apart."
Setting the agenda	"I thought we could start with your requirements, then I'll walk you through how I'd approach it. Does that work?"

Understanding what they need

Situation	What to say
Opening question	"Tell me a bit about what you're trying to build, and what problem it solves for you."
Digging deeper	"Can you walk me through how that works today?" / "What happens right now when a customer does that?"
Priorities	"If we could only ship one thing first, what would deliver the most value?"
Timeline	"Do you have a deadline you're working towards, or is the timeline flexible?"
Budget (the hard one)	"Do you have a budget range in mind for this? It helps me recommend the right approach."
Confirming you understood	"So just to make sure I've got this right — you need [X] so that [Y]. Is that accurate?"

When you don't understand (the most important section)

Situation	What to say
Didn't catch it	"Sorry, I didn't catch that last part — could you say it again?"
Too fast	"Could you slow down just a little? I want to make sure I get all the details."
Unknown term	"When you say [term], do you mean [your guess]?" — this sounds engaged, not lost.
Bad connection	"You cut out for a second there — could you repeat that?"
Buying time	"That's a good question — let me think about that for a second."
Need to check	"I'd rather give you an accurate answer than a quick one — can I confirm that and get back to you today?"

Giving updates & bad news

Situation	What to say
Good progress	"We're on track. The [feature] is done and I'll have [next thing] ready by Thursday."
A delay	"I want to flag something early: [X] is taking longer than I estimated because [reason]. I expect it done by [date]. I'll keep you posted."
A mistake you made	"I made a mistake on [X]. Here's what happened, here's how I fixed it, and here's what I've changed so it doesn't happen again."
Blocked by them	"I'm blocked on [X] until I get [the API key / the content / your feedback]. Once I have that, it's about two days of work."

Difficult conversations

Situation	What to say
Scope creep	"Happy to add that — it's outside what we originally agreed, so it would add about [X] days and [Y] to the cost. Shall I send an updated estimate?"
Disagreeing politely	"I see what you mean. My concern with that approach is [reason]. What if we did [alternative] instead?"
Saying no	"That's not something I can take on right now, but I'd be glad to point you to someone who can."
Raising your rate	"My rate for new projects is now [X]. I've really enjoyed working with you, and I'd like to keep going if that works on your side."
Chasing payment	"Just following up on invoice [number] from [date] — could you let me know when I can expect it? Happy to resend if it got lost."

Closing the call

Situation	What to say
Summarizing	"So to summarize: I'll send you a proposal by Wednesday covering [X and Y], and you'll send me [the assets]."
Next steps	"What would you like the next step to be?"
Ending warmly	"Thanks again for your time — I'll be in touch on Wednesday. Have a good rest of your day."

TECHNICAL ENGLISH FOR DEVELOPERS

You already know these concepts — this section is about saying them out loud, and about having two versions of every explanation: one for engineers and one for the client paying the bill. Being able to switch between the two is a genuinely senior skill and clients notice it immediately.

THE TWO-VERSION RULE

Concept	To an engineer	To a non-technical client
Redis caching	"I'm caching the product listings in Redis with a 5-minute TTL."	"The site remembers popular pages for a few minutes, so they load instantly instead of rebuilding every time."
Celery background tasks	"I moved report generation to a Celery worker."	"Big reports now run in the background, so your dashboard doesn't freeze while they're being built."
Database indexing	"I added a composite index on those two columns."	"Searches that took four seconds now take under half a second."
Automated tests	"There's pytest coverage on the checkout flow, gated in CI."	"Before any change goes live, the system automatically checks that checkout still works — so we don't break what's already working."
Technical debt	"That module needs refactoring before we extend it."	"We can build this feature fast now, but it'll slow down everything after it. I'd suggest two extra days to do it properly."

STANDUP AND TEAM ENGLISH

- ◆ "Yesterday I finished the [X]. Today I'm working on [Y]. I'm blocked on [Z]." — the universal standup structure.
- ◆ "I'll pick that up." / "I can take that one." — volunteering for a task.
- ◆ "Can I get a second pair of eyes on this PR?" — asking for a code review.
- ◆ "This looks good to me — just one small suggestion on line 40." — approving a review kindly.
- ◆ "I'm not sure I follow — can you walk me through the flow?" — admitting confusion without losing credibility.
- ◆ "Let's take this offline." — moving a long side-discussion out of a group meeting.

ESTIMATING AND COMMITTING (SAY THESE CAREFULLY)

- ◆ "Roughly two to three days, assuming the API documentation is accurate." — always attach the assumption.
- ◆ "I'd rather give you a proper estimate tomorrow than guess now." — completely acceptable and looks professional.
- ◆ "That's a bigger change than it looks — let me break it down for you."
- ◆ Avoid 'I will try' for commitments. Say 'I'll have it to you by Thursday' or say a different date.

WRITTEN ENGLISH: EMAILS, PROPOSALS & MORE

Western business English is **shorter and less formal** than most Pakistani English training teaches. Long, ornate, extremely polite emails read as dated or even insincere to American and European clients. Aim for warm, direct and brief.

EMAIL STRUCTURE THAT ALWAYS WORKS

- 1 **Subject line:** specific, not vague. “BTR Mall — checkout ready for review”, not “Update”.
- 2 **One-line greeting:** “Hi Sarah,” — ‘Hi’ is correct and normal in business email; ‘Respected Sir’ is not.
- 3 **The point, in the first sentence.** Don't build up to it. “The payment integration is done and ready for you to test.”
- 4 **Details or context,** 2–4 short lines or bullets.
- 5 **One clear ask or next step:** “Could you test it and let me know by Friday?”
- 6 **Short sign-off:** “Thanks, Nouman” or “Best, Nouman”.

SWAP THESE PHRASES

Instead of...	Write...	Why
“Please do the needful”	“Could you please [specific action]?”	Western clients often don't know this phrase, and it's vague.
“Kindly revert back”	“Let me know when you can.”	‘Revert’ means undo a change; ‘revert back’ is also redundant.
“I am having a doubt”	“I have a question about...”	‘Doubt’ suggests you distrust them, not that you're unsure.
“Prepone the meeting”	“Move the meeting earlier”	‘Prepone’ is South Asian English only.
“Respected Sir/Madam”	“Hi [First name],”	First names are standard in Western business, even with senior people.
“I will try to finish it”	“I'll have it done by Thursday”	‘Try’ reads as ‘probably won't happen’.
“Same same” / “only” as filler	Just remove it	Direct translation from Urdu sentence patterns.

WHERE ELSE YOUR WRITTEN ENGLISH IS JUDGED

- ◆ **GitHub READMEs** — recruiters read these. Explain the problem the project solves, in three sentences, before any setup instructions.
- ◆ **Commit messages** — ‘Fix cart total calculation for discounted items’, not ‘fix bug’. Small habit, visible to everyone.
- ◆ **Slack** — shorter and more casual than email. Short lines, no formal greeting, emojis are normal.
- ◆ **LinkedIn posts** — doubles as career-roadmap visibility. One idea per post, short paragraphs.
- ◆ **Proposals** — see Mission 6. Under 150 words, personalized, with one clear next step.

COMMON MISTAKES FOR URDU / PUNJABI SPEAKERS

These errors come from Urdu sentence structure rather than from not knowing English — which is why they persist even in strong speakers. Fixing this short list removes most of what marks your English as non-native in writing.

Mistake	Correct	Why it happens
"I am working here since 2 years"	"I've been working here for two years"	Urdu uses present tense for ongoing duration; English needs present perfect continuous + 'for'.
"I am having a car"	"I have a car"	State verbs (have, know, understand, want) don't take continuous form.
"Yesterday I have gone"	"Yesterday I went"	A finished time (yesterday, last week) always takes past simple.
"I went to office"	"I went to the office"	Urdu has no articles, so a/an/the get dropped constantly.
"Discuss about the project"	"Discuss the project"	Some English verbs take no preposition: discuss, request, enter, marry.
"I didn't went"	"I didn't go"	After did/didn't, the verb stays in base form.
"Open the light"	"Turn on the light"	Direct translation of the Urdu verb.
"What you are doing?"	"What are you doing?"	English inverts the subject and verb in questions; Urdu doesn't.
"He is elder than me"	"He is older than me"	'Elder' only works inside a family, before a noun.
"Give me one advice"	"Give me some advice"	Advice, information, equipment, software are uncountable — no 'one/an', no plural 's'.
"I will inform you back"	"I'll let you know"	Literal translation; the natural English phrase is completely different.
"Myself Nouman"	"I'm Nouman"	Common South Asian introduction pattern that sounds odd to Western ears.

"Don't try to fix all twelve at once. Pick two per week, watch for them specifically in your daily recordings, and move on. Twelve weeks, twelve fixed patterns, and most of your accent-in-writing is gone."

PRONUNCIATION: THE SOUNDS THAT GIVE YOU AWAY

An accent is completely fine — do not spend a single hour trying to sound American. But a handful of specific sounds genuinely cause misunderstanding on calls, and those are worth fixing. Everything below is about **clarity**, not accent removal.

Sound	The problem	How to fix it
V vs W	'very' and 'wery', 'wine' and 'vine' sound the same — Urdu doesn't distinguish them.	For V, your top teeth must touch your bottom lip. For W, lips round, teeth touch nothing. Practice: 'very wet weather'.
TH (two kinds)	'think' becomes 'tink', 'this' becomes 'dis'.	Tongue tip lightly between your teeth. Practice: 'I think this thing is theirs'. Exaggerate it at first.
Word stress	Stressing the wrong syllable makes a familiar word unrecognizable — this causes more confusion than any individual sound.	DE-velop-er, da-ta-BASE is wrong — it's DA-tabase, de-VE-loper, RE-quirements. Check stress on new technical words.
Silent letters	Pronouncing every written letter: 'debt', 'receipt', 'island', 'Wednesday'.	Learn these individually as you meet them. Listen before you assume the spelling.
Speed	Speaking fast to hide uncertainty — the most common issue on client calls.	Deliberately slow down 20%. Slow, clear English sounds confident; fast unclear English sounds nervous.
Sentence rhythm	Every word given equal weight, so speech sounds flat and is hard to follow.	English stresses the important words and rushes the small ones. This is exactly what shadowing (Mission 2) trains.

How to practice: record yourself reading a short technical paragraph. Listen back once for V/W, once for TH, once for speed. Three focused passes beat one vague listen. Do this weekly, not daily — pronunciation improves mostly through shadowing, not through drills.

MASTER TIMELINE & MILESTONES

Eight months at 45 minutes a day, with the missions layered on top. Run this in parallel with your Master Career Roadmap — the two are designed to share material and finish around the same time.

Month	Focus	Missions running	Milestone
1	Phase 1: core tenses, articles, questions; daily habit formation	1, 2	30 days without missing a voice note
2	Phase 1 continues; first tutor conversations from week 3	1, 2	2-minute monologue with no long silences
3	Phase 2 begins: fluency over accuracy, real-speed listening	1, 2, 3, 4	Thinking in English on familiar topics
4	Phase 2 continues: 2 tutor calls/week, unprepared topics	1, 3, 4	30-min conversation without switching to Urdu
5	Phase 3 begins: client scenarios, difficult conversations	3, 4, 5, 7	First demo video published
6	Phase 3 continues: proposals, negotiation, interview English	5, 6, 7	10 real proposals sent
7	Real-world application alongside your job search	6, 7, 8	FIRST REAL CLIENT CALL IN ENGLISH
8+	Maintenance: keep speaking daily, refine weak areas	1, 3, 4	English is no longer the blocker

"If you only do one thing from this entire document, do Mission 1: sixty seconds of recorded English every day. Everything else amplifies that habit; nothing replaces it."

RESOURCES, TOOLS & FINAL CHECKLIST

SPEAKING PRACTICE (SPEND YOUR MONEY HERE)

- ◆ **italki / Preply** — conversation tutors from roughly \$5–10/hour. A ‘community tutor’ is cheaper than a professional teacher and perfectly good for conversation practice.
- ◆ **Tandem / HelloTalk** — free language exchange; you help someone with Urdu, they help you with English.
- ◆ **Toastmasters** — many Pakistani cities have chapters, and online clubs exist. Structured public speaking in English, very cheap.
- ◆ **Any friend or colleague** who agrees to only speak English with you for 30 minutes a week.

LISTENING

- ◆ BBC Learning English — best free structured content for Phase 1.
- ◆ Tech podcasts: Syntax, Software Engineering Daily, Lex Fridman — real speed, relevant vocabulary.
- ◆ Conference talks on YouTube (DjangoCon, PyCon) — your exact domain, clear speakers, free.
- ◆ Any Netflix show with English subtitles — watch once with subtitles, once without.

GRAMMAR & VOCABULARY (MINIMAL — DON'T OVER-INVEST HERE)

- ◆ **English Grammar in Use** (Raymond Murphy) — the one grammar book worth owning. Use it as a reference, not a course.
- ◆ **Anki** — free spaced-repetition app for your personal phrase deck. Only add phrases you personally needed.
- ◆ **Grammarly** (free tier) — for written work; read the explanations rather than blindly accepting fixes.
- ◆ **YouGlish** — type any word and hear it used by hundreds of real speakers. Excellent for stress and pronunciation.

BUSINESS & CLIENT ENGLISH

- ◆ Search YouTube for ‘freelance discovery call example’ and ‘client onboarding call’ — watch how the phrases in Section 16 are used naturally.
- ◆ Upwork’s own proposal guidelines — short, practical, and written by the platform that pays you.
- ◆ This document’s Sections 16–18 — keep them open during real calls and real emails. That’s what they’re for.

FINAL CHECKLIST — YOU'RE CLIENT-READY WHEN YOU CAN...

- ✓ Speak for 3 minutes about a project you built, unprepared, without long silences.
- ✓ Understand a native speaker at natural speed, on a slightly bad connection, without subtitles.
- ✓ Ask a client clarifying questions about requirements, budget and timeline in real time.
- ✓ Say ‘I didn’t catch that, could you repeat it?’ without feeling embarrassed.
- ✓ Explain a technical decision in two versions: one for engineers, one for the person paying.
- ✓ Tell a client about a delay, early and clearly, without over-apologizing.
- ✓ Push back politely on a bad idea or a scope change, and propose an alternative.
- ✓ Write a 150-word proposal in 15 minutes that sounds like you, not like a template.
- ✓ Record a 90-second demo video in three takes instead of fifteen.
- ✓ Finish a real client call and realize you weren’t thinking about your English at all.

"Your English does not need to be better than your competition's. It needs to be good enough that it stops being the reason a client says no. For a backend engineer with your portfolio, that bar is much lower than it feels right now — and six months of daily speaking will clear it."

Prepared for Muhammad Nouman — Python Backend Engineer & Founder, Xvera Labs. A companion to the Master Career Roadmap (Full-Stack + DevOps + QA + DSA + Agentic AI).